

Haligric Research Integration Series

GERMANIC PRE-CHRISTIAN TRADITIONS & HEATHENRY

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*Wodan, Donar, the Wild Hunt, Blót, Sumbel, the Völva, and the Living
Revival of Heathenry*

Wednesday is Woden's day. Thursday belongs to Donar, the Thunderer. The Wild Hunt rides through the December sky and the old woman shakes her featherbed and the snow falls. The seers sat on their high platforms and the songs pulled the spirits close. This is the tradition that gave the modern world four of its weekday names, the Christian holiday of Easter, and the word Yule — a tradition that was driven underground by military conquest and forced baptism, preserved in fairy tales and folklore, and revived in Iceland in 1972 by twelve people who decided the old gods were not dead.

The Germanic pre-Christian tradition is the broadest sacred inheritance in northern Europe — spanning from the continental Franks, Saxons, and Alemanni to the Anglo-Saxons of England to the Norse of Scandinavia. What the Norse volume of this series covers: runes, the Norse pantheon, Yggdrasil, Wicca. What this volume covers: the continental Germanic tradition that Norse mythology grew from; the specifically Anglo-Saxon tradition with its distinct deities and calendar; the Wild Hunt and the winter goddess complex; the blót and sumbel ceremonies in full step-by-step detail; the völva and seiðr practice; the cosmological framework of wyrd, orlog, frith, and hamingja; and the modern revival — Ásatrú, Heathenry, and the ongoing battle to reclaim the tradition from those who would weaponize it for hate.

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Introduction

The Root System Beneath Norse Mythology

Norse mythology is the tip of an iceberg. The gods Odin, Thor, and Freya — the nine worlds, the runes, the Eddas — represent one branch, the best-documented branch, of a much larger and older tradition that once spread across the entire Germanic-speaking world from the Rhine to Iceland, from the North Sea coast to the Alpine foothills. That larger tradition is what this document addresses.

The Germanic peoples — a cultural and linguistic family, not a single ethnic group — inhabited Europe from at least the Iron Age onward, and their sacred tradition was one of the most widespread in the pre-Christian world. The Franks, Saxons, Angles, Jutes, Frisians, Alemanni, Goths, Lombards, and Vandals all practiced related forms of the same fundamental tradition, worshipping versions of the same gods under different names, performing the same essential ceremonies in their own regional forms, and understanding the cosmos through the same fundamental framework. By the end of the 10th century, only the Scandinavians remained openly pagan — the rest had been Christianized, in most cases by force.

The consequence of this forced Christianization is that our record of the continental and Anglo-Saxon Germanic traditions is fragmentary — preserved in Roman ethnographic accounts, in a handful of surviving charm texts, in the fairy tales and folk traditions that carried the old sacred world in disguised form, and in the full Norse documentation that survived Iceland's relatively late and relatively peaceful conversion. The Norse Eddas are thus not just Nordic documents — they are the most complete surviving record of a tradition that once belonged to all the Germanic peoples.

This document does not repeat what the Norse/Runes volume already covers in depth: the full Elder Futhark, Norse cosmology, the Aesir and Vanir pantheon, the Norns and Wyrð, Valhalla and the afterlife. It addresses what that volume does not: the continental and Anglo-Saxon traditions, the specific ceremonies of blót and sumbel, the völvu and seiðr practice, and the full story of the modern Heathenry revival.

Origins — The Proto-Germanic Sacred World

From the Iron Age to the Roman Encounter

The Germanic sacred tradition did not begin with the Viking Age. Its roots reach into the European Iron Age — approximately 500 BCE onward — when the peoples who would become the Germanic nations first emerge as a distinct cultural group from the broader Indo-European family. Their sacred tradition shows clear structural parallels with the Celtic, Roman, and Greek traditions that share the same Indo-European root: a thunder god (Þunraz — Thor/Donar), a sky/wisdom/wanderer god (Wōðanaz — Odin/Woden), a god of justice and sacred law (Tiwaz — Tyr/Tiw), and a female divine force associated with fertility, the earth, and the sea (Nerthus — cognate with Norse Njord).

The Proto-Germanic sacred world as reconstructed by scholars was primarily animistic and polytheistic: the living world was populated by divine and semi-divine presences — gods, land spirits (landvættir), ancestral spirits (the dísir and álfar), and various beings of uncertain nature. Worship took place primarily outdoors — in sacred groves (the hearg or hörgr), at specific trees, springs, and mountains — rather than in temples. The sacred grove was the primary cultic site, and the religious act of greatest importance was the sacrifice: the blót, in which animals (and in certain contexts humans) were offered to the relevant divine beings in exchange for their ongoing support and blessing.

The origin myth of the Germanic peoples, as recorded by Tacitus, traced the nation to Tuisto — an earth-born divine being — and his son Mannus, from whom the three branches of the Germanic peoples (the Ingaevones, Herminones, and Istaevones) descended. This founder mythology located the sacred origin of the people in a specific divine lineage and specific territory, giving the land itself a sacred character as the inheritance of those descendants.

Tacitus and the Primary Sources

What Rome Saw — and What It Missed

The most important primary source for the continental Germanic sacred tradition is Tacitus's *Germania*, written approximately 98 CE — a Latin ethnographic account of the Germanic tribes beyond the Rhine and Danube, written by a Roman historian who (as far as we know) never visited the region himself but drew on earlier accounts, including the now-lost *Bella Germaniae* of Pliny the Elder, and on reports from Romans who had campaigned in or traded with Germanic territory.

What Tacitus records: The Germanic peoples worship their gods primarily in the open air, in sacred groves, considering it an absurdity to confine the divine within walls or represent it in human form. Their chief god is one he calls Mercury — almost certainly Wōðanaz/Woden — to whom, on specific holy days, human sacrifices are offered. Hercules (Donar/Thor) and Mars (Tiwaz/Tiw) receive animal sacrifice. The goddess Nerthus — Mother Earth — is the most specifically described female deity, housed in a sacred grove on an island in the sea, her processional wagon covered so no profane eye may see what it carries. When Nerthus moves through the land in her wagon, all weapons are laid down and peace reigns; when she returns to her grove, her wagon, her priest, and the servants who have seen her are drowned in a sacred lake.

What Tacitus misses or distorts: His account is filtered through Roman categories and Roman political purposes — the Germans needed to appear simultaneously impressive enough to justify Roman military effort against them and barbarous enough to justify Roman cultural superiority. The human sacrifice accounts are particularly contested; modern archaeology has found limited evidence supporting the scale of human sacrifice Tacitus describes, though specific ritual killings (the bog bodies of Denmark and northern Germany) do attest to some form of sacrificial practice. The sources must be read with their biases clearly understood.

Other key sources: the Prose and Poetic Eddas (Iceland, 13th century — the Norse branch at its most documented), the Anglo-Saxon *Beowulf* (England, composed possibly 8th century — the richest surviving literary source for Anglo-Saxon sacred culture), Bede's *De Temporum Ratione* (England, 725 CE — the primary source for Anglo-Saxon month names and their divine associations), the Sagas (Iceland, 12th–14th centuries), and the Merseburg Charms (Germany, 9th–10th century — the only surviving pre-Christian literary text in Old High German).

The Continental Germanic Tradition

Woden, Donar, Tiw, and the Sacred World of the Franks, Saxons, and Alemanni

The continental Germanic tradition — the sacred world of the Franks, Saxons, Alemanni, Langobards, and related peoples — is the least documented and most fragmentary branch of the Germanic tradition. Most of it was destroyed or driven underground during Christianization between the 4th and 8th centuries CE. What survives is reconstructed from Roman accounts, archaeological evidence, place names, folk traditions, and the comparative evidence of the Norse branch.

Woden (Old High German: Wotan; Old Saxon: Guodan; ancestral form: Wōðanaz) was the chief deity of the continental Germanic tradition — the god of wisdom, war, inspiration, ecstatic states, and the dead. His name derives from Proto-Germanic wōðanaz — "raging" or "inspired," linking him to ecstatic states and martial fury. Evidence for his continental veneration appears in 7th-century artifacts including the Nordendorf fibula (an inscribed brooch from Bavaria) and in the personal names and place names embedded in the Germanic landscape.

Donar (Old High German for Thor; related to the Old English Þunor and the ancestral Þunraz) was the thunder god — protector of the community, the deity most commonly invoked by ordinary people, as Thor was in the Norse world. The destruction of Donar's Oak by the Anglo-Saxon missionary Boniface in 724 CE (in the territory of the Chatti tribe, in present-day Hesse, Germany) was a deliberate act of sacred desecration intended to demonstrate that the Germanic gods could not protect their sacred sites from a Christian missionary — and the fact that no lightning struck Boniface down was taken as proof of the Christian God's superior power. The destruction worked. Conversions followed. The oak had been the primary sacred site of Donar worship in that region.

Tiw (Old High German: Ziu; ancestral form: Tiwaz) was the god of justice, sacred law, and honorable combat. His name is the oldest attested Germanic divine name, cognate with the Latin deus and the Greek Zeus, reflecting the Proto-Indo-European sky-father deity. He gives his name to Tuesday. In Norse mythology he appears as Tyr, most famous for sacrificing his hand to bind the wolf Fenrir.

Nerthus — Mother Earth — is the most completely described continental Germanic deity in Tacitus, and the one with the most developed ritual account. Her processional ceremony — the wagon tour of the land bringing peace and fertility, concluded with the ritual drowning of those who had seen her most sacred form — is one of the most complete descriptions of Germanic sacred ceremony in any ancient source. She is widely understood as the continental form of the Norse Njord (the male fertility deity) or as the female counterpart of that deity family.

The Germanic Weekday Names

The most lasting legacy of the continental Germanic sacred tradition in everyday life is the four weekday names that encode the Germanic gods in the English language. Tuesday is Tiw's Day (from Tiwaz/Tiw). Wednesday is Woden's Day (from Wōðanaz/Woden). Thursday is Donar's/Þunor's Day (the Thunder God). Friday is Frig's Day or Freya's Day (the Germanic equivalent of the Roman Venus's Day — the female divine of love, beauty, and fertility). These names were established during the early medieval period through a process scholars call *interpretatio germanica* — the deliberate mapping of Germanic gods onto the

Roman planetary week, producing a hybrid calendar in which four days honor the pre-Christian Germanic divine world every time we name the day.

The Irminsul and the Saxon Wars

The Last Stand of Continental Germanic Paganism

The most dramatic episode in the Christianization of the continental Germanic tradition is the Saxon Wars — the thirty-three year conflict (772–804 CE) between the Frankish king Charlemagne and the Saxon people of northern Germany, whose explicit goal was the forced conversion of the last major openly pagan Germanic people in continental Europe.

The Irminsul (Old Saxon: Irminsûl — great pillar, gigantic pillar) was the central sacred site of Saxon paganism — a great wooden pillar or sacred tree near the fortress of Eresburg (modern Obermarsberg, North Rhine-Westphalia) understood as the axis mundi of the Saxon sacred world: the pillar that upheld the universe, equivalent in function to the Norse Yggdrasil. Its precise nature is debated — whether a carved wooden idol, a sacred natural tree, or a constructed pillar — but its significance to Saxon identity and worship is not.

In the spring of 772 CE, Charlemagne led his army into Saxony, seized the fortress of Eresburg, and destroyed the Irminsul — carrying off its gold and silver offerings. The Royal Frankish Annals record this as the central sacred act of the opening campaign. A providential drought that halted the army for two days before completing the destruction was interpreted in the Frankish chronicles as divine favor for the Christian king. A church was erected on the site and blessed by Pope Leo III in 783.

The Saxons fought back — repeatedly. The Stellinga uprising of 841–842 CE, forty years after the official end of the Saxon Wars, was a Saxon rebellion explicitly aimed at returning to the old ways: the rebelling Saxons rejected baptism and re-established pagan practices. It was crushed. The *Capitulatio de partibus Saxoniae* (785 CE) — Charlemagne's legal code for the conquered Saxons — prescribed death for practicing pagan sacrifice, cremating the dead (a specifically Germanic funerary practice), failure to be baptized, and numerous other observances of the old tradition. The Massacre at Verden in 782 CE, in which Charlemagne ordered the execution of 4,500 Saxon prisoners who had refused baptism or relapsed into paganism, is the most extreme single act of violence in the Christianization of the Germanic peoples. The Saxon Wars created the documentary silence about the continental Germanic tradition that makes it so difficult to reconstruct today: the tradition was not preserved in writing, and the people who might have preserved it were killed or terrorized into silence.

The Merseburg Charms

The Only Surviving Pre-Christian Old High German Literary Text

Among the most remarkable survivals from the continental Germanic sacred tradition are the Merseburg Charms — two short texts discovered in 1841 written in the blank spaces of a 9th or 10th-century Latin manuscript in the library of Merseburg Cathedral. They are the only surviving pre-Christian literary texts in Old High German — two magical healing spells that carry within them the names of the continental Germanic gods and a cosmological framework that aligns with the Norse tradition.

The First Merseburg Charm is a release charm — a spell for freeing prisoners, drawing on the precedent of the Idisi (female divine beings, cognate with Norse *dísir*) who released warriors from bonds. The charm invokes their power: "The Idisi sat down, sat down here and there. Some buckled on armor, some hindered an army, some picked at fetters — spring free from fetters, escape from enemies."

The Second Merseburg Charm is a healing charm for a horse's sprained leg — and within it, the gods themselves appear. Phol (an otherwise unknown deity) and Woden were riding to the wood; Balder's foal sprained its foot. Sinthgunt (sister of Sunna, the sun goddess) sang her charm; Frija (the ancestral Germanic form of Norse Frigg) sang her charm; Woden sang his charm — and healed the sprain with the specific spoken formula: "bone to bone, blood to blood, joint to joint — as if they were glued together." This incantation preserves a cosmological moment — the gods acting in the world through sacred speech — that maps directly onto the Norse sacred tradition while demonstrating the specifically continental Germanic expression of it.

The Charms were written into the margin of a Christian manuscript in a Christian cathedral — testament to how thoroughly the pre-Christian tradition had been driven underground and how it survived: not in openly maintained practice but in fragments, in folk medicine, in the specific words of healing spells that were too practically useful to discard even as their sacred context was officially suppressed.

Anglo-Saxon Paganism — Fyrnsidu

Woden, Eostre, Hretha, and the Old English Sacred Calendar

The Anglo-Saxon branch of the Germanic tradition — the sacred world of the Angles, Saxons, and Jutes who settled Britain from the 5th century CE onward — is a distinct tradition from both the continental Germanic and the Norse traditions, with its own specific deities, its own calendar, and its own surviving literary monument (the epic *Beowulf*). Modern practitioners of this tradition call it Fyrnsidu — the Old Customs — to distinguish it from Norse-centered Heathenry.

Wōden (Anglo-Saxon) is the primary deity of the Anglo-Saxon tradition — cognate with Norse Odin and continental Woden, but with specifically Anglo-Saxon characteristics. He is the ancestor of the Anglo-Saxon royal dynasties: virtually every Anglo-Saxon royal genealogy traces its lineage back to Wōden, establishing the divine right of kings through direct ancestral connection to the chief deity. Þunor (thunder) is the Anglo-Saxon Thor/Donar. Tīw is the Anglo-Saxon Tyr/Tiw. These three, with Frig (the female divine, parallel to Frigg), give us the four Anglo-Saxon weekday names that survive unchanged into modern English.

The Distinctly Anglo-Saxon Deities

Bede's *De Temporum Ratione* (725 CE) — written to help the Christian church calculate the date of Easter — preserves the names and brief descriptions of the Anglo-Saxon month-names and their associated sacred observances. From this source we know of two goddesses not attested in the Norse tradition: Hretha and Eostre.

Hretha (Hrēþe) — goddess of the month Hrēþmōnaþ (March) — is described by Bede only as the deity to whom the Anglo-Saxons sacrificed in that month. Her name connects etymologically to concepts of glory, victory, or honor. She is widely understood as a spring goddess associated with the final conquest of winter and the first stirring of the land's fertility. The month of March, dedicated to Hretha, precedes Eostre's month of April in a sequence that reads as the two faces of spring's arrival.

Eostre (Ēostre) — goddess of the month Ēosturmōnaþ (April) — is the deity to whom the Anglo-Saxons celebrated feasts in that month, according to Bede. Her name is directly ancestral to the English word Easter — the Christian festival of resurrection absorbed her month name. Eostre is connected etymologically to the Proto-Germanic goddess of the dawn, Austrō, the personification of the rising sun. The 19th-century scholar Jacob Grimm argued in his *Teutonic Mythology* that a continental Germanic form, Ostara, was also worshipped — though this claim rests primarily on inferential evidence. Eostre's connection to eggs, rabbits, and spring fertility — transmitted through folk custom into Christian Easter practice — suggests that specific sacred practices associated with her month survived the conversion.

Mōdraniht — Night of the Mothers

Bede also records that the Anglo-Saxons celebrated Mōdraniht (Night of the Mothers) on what would become Christmas Eve — a ceremony dedicated to the Modra, the divine Mothers, cognate with the continental Matres and Matronae (the triple goddess figures documented extensively in Roman-era inscriptions from the Germanic and Celtic lands) and with the Norse dísir. The Mothers were ancestral female divine beings whose blessing

governed the fertility of the family, the household, and the land. Mōdraniht was the most sacred night of the Anglo-Saxon calendar — the night the divine Mothers were closest and their blessing most accessible.

The Wild Hunt

Woden's Ride and the Spectral Army of the Dead

The Wild Hunt is one of the most widespread and most enduring sacred traditions in the Germanic world — a spectral procession of riders, horses, hounds, and the dead sweeping through the winter sky in a terrifying cavalcade that crosses the barrier between the living world and the world of the dead. It is attested across the entire Germanic area — Norse, Anglo-Saxon, continental German, and Scandinavian — and its essential character remains consistent: a divine or semi-divine leader, a host of the dead, winter storms as the vehicle, and specific human protocols for surviving the encounter.

The Leader

In the Germanic lands, the figure most consistently associated with leading the Wild Hunt is Woden/Odin, who carries two of his bynames specifically relating to the season of the Hunt: Jólnir and Jauloherra, both translating as Master of Yule. As the god of the dead — the divine figure who receives half of all who die in battle, who rides through the nine worlds on Sleipnir his eight-legged horse, who is the ultimate shamanic journeyer — Odin's association with the winter procession of the dead is structurally inevitable. Other leaders appear in regional variants: Frau Holle and Frau Perchta lead the Hunt in southern German tradition; Herne the Hunter leads it in English folklore; Herla and various local noble figures appear in medieval chronicles.

The Hunt in Action

The Hunt rides during the Twelve Nights — the liminal period between Yule (the winter solstice) and the New Year, when the boundary between the human world and the world of the dead is understood to be at its thinnest. The howling of the winter wind is the sound of the Hunt. The crack of thunder on a winter night is the hooves of the spectral horses. To see the Hunt is dangerous. Medieval accounts are specific about the protocols: fall flat on the ground face-down when the Hunt passes overhead; lie still and do not look up; do not speak. In some Scandinavian traditions, the Hunt does not ride lower than the height of an ox's yoke, so dropping to the earth gives safety.

Before Christianity darkened its reputation entirely, the Wild Hunt carried a dual significance. The older layers of the tradition suggest that the procession could be propitiated: offerings of food and drink left on doorsteps were consumed by the Hunt's passage, and those who gave generously might receive blessings in return. The Hunt arriving was not only an omen of chaos but also a distribution of winter's blessing — the dead returning to check on the living, the divine force of winter asserting its claim and moving on. The Christian layer stripped the blessing dimension and left only the terror.

The Wild Hunt and Santa Claus

One of the most directly traceable connections between the Germanic sacred tradition and modern popular culture runs through the Wild Hunt to Father Christmas. Odin's midwinter ride on Sleipnir — the eight-legged horse whose stride covers enormous distances — his role as gift-giver and harbinger of winter, his white beard and dark cloak, his descent through smoke holes and chimneys in folk tradition (bringing gifts to those who had honored him), and his two ravens that report the doings of humanity all map directly onto the figure of Santa Claus, whose Dutch form Sinterklaas descends from St. Nicholas but

whose specific attributes (the sled, the eight reindeer, the chimney descent, the global nocturnal journey) appear to draw substantially from the Odin/Wild Hunt tradition as it was processed through Dutch and German Christian folk custom.

Frau Holle and Frau Perchta

The Winter Goddess Complex of the Continental Tradition

Among the most significant survivals of the continental Germanic sacred tradition in post-Christianization folk culture are the winter goddess figures known across the German-speaking world as Frau Holle (or Holda) and Frau Perchta (or Berchta). These are not equivalent figures but regional variants of what appears to have been a common pre-Christian divine female presence — the mistress of the winter season, guardian of the household and its productivity, psychopomp of the dead (particularly the unbaptized dead of infants), and periodic leader of the Wild Hunt.

Frau Holle — The Generous Winter Lady

Frau Holle (prevalent in Hesse and Thuringia — central Germany) is the gentler face of the winter goddess: when she shakes her featherbed, the snow falls on the world below; when she wrings out her washing, it rains; when she lights her fire, morning fog rises. She is the guardian of spinning — those who complete their spinning before the Twelve Nights receive her blessing; the lazy receive punishment. The Grimm fairy tale Frau Holle encodes her essential character: a woman who falls into a sacred well enters her underground realm, works diligently, and is rewarded with gold; her lazy sister goes the same way but earns only pitch. Holle also functions as a guide of the dead — particularly the souls of infants who die unbaptized, who follow her procession. She is connected to the dead specifically in the form of the Wild Hunt, in which she rides as leader in the northern German variants.

Frau Perchta — The Fierce Winter Enforcer

Frau Perchta (prevalent in the Alpine regions — Austria, Bavaria, Switzerland) is the more terrifying face of the same divine presence. She walks through settlements during the Twelve Nights between Christmas and Epiphany, inspecting homes for signs of industry and order. Those who have completed their spinning and kept their homes well receive blessings. Those who have been idle face a specific punishment that appears repeatedly across Alpine folklore with remarkable consistency: Perchta slits open their bellies, removes whatever food she finds inside (not the prescribed holiday food — gruel and fish — but other things), and sews them back up using a plowshare as a needle and a chain as thread. Today in parts of Austria and Bavaria, the Perchtenlauf processions — groups of masked figures (Schönperchten and Schiachperchten, beautiful and ugly Perchtas) run noisily through streets during the Twelve Nights, their horned and bell-laden costumes directly ancestral to the figure of Krampus.

The Scholarly Understanding

Both Holle and Perchta were systematically demonized by the Church — sermons condemned "Domina Perchta" as a demonic figure, and the women who claimed to participate in her nightly rides in spirit form (a specific form of ecstatic religious practice attested in Alpine communities from at least the 14th century) were subjected to increasing suspicion and eventually prosecution. The scholar Lotte Motz established both figures as regional variants of a single pre-Christian divine woman of winter whose attributes — control of the weather, guardianship of spinning and household work, care for the souls of the dead, and periodic nocturnal procession — remained remarkably consistent across the Germanic-speaking world despite centuries of official suppression.

Blót — The Sacrifice Ceremony

The Central Ritual of Germanic Sacred Practice — Step by Step

The blót (Old Norse and Old English; from Proto-Germanic *blōtanan — to sacrifice, to worship through offering) is the most important ritual in the Germanic sacred tradition: a ceremonial sacrifice to a deity, ancestral spirit, or land spirit, followed by a communal feast, through which the human community and the divine world enter into a specific reciprocal relationship of gift and counter-gift.

The gifting cycle is the theological foundation of the blót: the Germanic understanding that the relationship between humans and the divine operates on the principle of gefa — to give. A gift demands a gift. The sacrifice is not propitiation of a hostile power (as Roman sacrifice often was) but participation in an ongoing relationship of mutual generosity. The gods give good harvests, healthy livestock, victory in battle, and fair winds. The community gives the gods the best of what they have. The relationship is maintained, and the world continues to function.

The Three Great Blóts

Snorri Sturluson in *Heimskringla* records three great annual blóts that structured the Nordic sacred year. Vetrnætr (Winter Nights, late October/November) — at the start of winter, a blót for a good year, a good harvest, and the blessing of the coming dark season. Often dedicated to the dísir (female ancestral spirits) and to Freyr and Freya. Jólablót (Yule, midwinter, around the winter solstice) — the midwinter blót for the returning sun, fertility, and prosperity; the great feast of the dead and of the divine. Sigrblót (Victory Blót, early April) — the spring blót for victory, success in the coming year, and the blessing of the summer season, dedicated to Odin and Tyr.

The Dísablót — specifically for the dísir (female ancestral spirits and fate-weavers) — was held in February in Sweden and was associated in Sweden with the great þing (assembly) and market at Uppsala. The Uppsala festival itself — described by Adam of Bremen in the 11th century — was the most dramatic recorded Germanic sacrificial ceremony: held every nine years, with nine individuals and nine of every male animal species sacrificed and hung from trees in the sacred grove adjacent to the temple. The bodies hung for nine days — nine being the sacred number of the Germanic tradition.

The Ceremony — Step by Step

Step 1 — Preparation: The animals for sacrifice are selected — the most appropriate species for the deity being honored (pigs and horses for fertility blóts dedicated to Freyr; cattle for abundance blóts; bulls for strength). The sacred space is prepared — the hof (temple) or the outdoor sacred enclosure, with the hörg (stone altar) or the sacred post.

Step 2 — The Consecration: The officiating goði (priest, male) or gyðja (priestess, female) consecrates the blót, opening the sacred space and calling on the deity to receive the offering.

Step 3 — The Killing: The animal is killed. The blood is caught in the hlautbolli — the sacred bowl. This blood is the most powerful element of the ceremony, carrying the force of the life given.

Step 4 — The Hlaut: The officiant uses the hlautteinn (the sacrifice twig or branch) to sprinkle the hlaut (blood) on the sacred objects — the statues of the gods, the walls of the hof, the altar stones — and on the participants. This sprinkling transfers the sacred force of the sacrifice to everything it touches, connecting the community to the divine through the medium of the offering's blood.

Step 5 — The Feast: The animal is cooked in great cauldrons. The meat is divided: the best portions for the gods (placed on the altar or burned), the rest shared among the community. To feast at a blót is to feast with the gods — the communal meal is simultaneously a sacred feast and a political act, with the ruler of the region presiding and his authority reinforced by his role as the person responsible for the blót.

Step 6 — The Sumbel: The feast concludes with the sumbel — the ritual toasting ceremony that closes the sacred gathering. Christian rulers who refused to hold blóts were, on multiple recorded occasions, driven from their lands by communities who regarded the blót as essential to the land's fertility and the community's survival. Blót was not optional religion — it was the constitutional act that maintained the world.

The Modern Blót

Contemporary Heathen communities have adapted the blót for modern contexts. Animal sacrifice is largely replaced by the sacrifice of food, drink (mead, ale, or appropriate beverages), crafted objects, or the burning of written offerings. The essential structure — the opening consecration, the offering to the relevant deity, the sharing of the sacred meal, and the sumbel — is maintained. Modern blóts are conducted by local kindreds (Heathen community groups) and by the national and international organizations of the Ásatrú revival.

Sumbel — The Sacred Feast

The Three-Round Ritual of Toasting, Boasting, and Oath — Step by Step

The sumbel (Old Norse: sumbl; Old English: symbel) is the sacred drinking ceremony that accompanied and concluded blót — a structured communal feast in which spoken words carry enormous weight, binding participants to each other, to their ancestors, and to their gods through the specific power of oath-speech spoken in sacred context. The sumbel is documented in Germanic sources from the 6th century through the Viking Age and appears in both Norse and Anglo-Saxon literary tradition. The Old English epic Beowulf contains the most sustained depiction of the symbel (lines 489-675) as a ritual at the heart of warrior culture and community identity.

The Theology of the Sumbel

Words spoken in sumbel are not casual conversation. They enter the fabric of wyrd — the interconnected web of fate that connects all beings and all actions. To speak at sumbel is to bind yourself. To make an oath at sumbel is to weave that oath into the causal structure of existence in a way that cannot be undone without consequence. The drinking horn cannot be set down until it is empty — this physical fact of the horn's shape enforces the shared experience of commitment. Every person present is a witness. The gods and ancestors are understood as present and listening. The Well of Urd — the Well of Fate — records everything spoken.

The Three Rounds — Step by Step

Step 1 — Preparation: The sumbel is opened by the goði or gyðja — the officiant. A drinking horn (or vessel) is filled with mead, ale, or other appropriate drink. Participants are seated in a circle or at a table in a hierarchical order reflecting their standing in the community.

Round One — To the Gods: The horn is passed clockwise around the circle. Each person raises it, speaks a toast to a specific deity (or to the Aesir and Vanir generally), and drinks. This round honors the divine and invites the gods' presence into the gathering. The first toast is typically to Odin for victory and kingship, followed by Njord or Freyr for peace and good harvest.

Round Two — To the Ancestors and Heroes: The horn passes again. Each person speaks the name of an ancestor, a hero, or a beloved dead, raising a toast to their memory and their deeds. This is the round of minni — "memory" — in which the dead are honored, their achievements celebrated, and their presence invoked. To speak a name at sumbel keeps the dead alive in the community's wyrd. The second round is the heart of the Heathen ancestor relationship: the living acknowledge that they stand on the foundation the dead built.

Round Three — Oaths, Boasts, and Gifting: The horn passes a third time, now open to individual speech. A person may make an oath — a binding promise spoken before the gods, ancestors, and community. A person may offer a boast — a truthful account of an achievement or a quality, acknowledging what one has accomplished and what one carries. A person may offer a gift in word — an acknowledgment of another's service or merit. Oaths sworn at sumbel are considered the most binding possible — the combined witness of the divine, the ancestral, and the human community creates a web of accountability that makes violation of the oath a cosmological transgression, not merely a social one.

The sumbel may continue beyond three rounds — "anything goes" in further rounds as long as what is spoken remains within the spirit of the sacred gathering. What is forbidden: lies, false boasts, and oaths the speaker knows they cannot keep.

The Völva and Seiðr

The Norse Shamanic Complex — Covered Here in Full Depth

Note: The Norse/Runes volume of this series introduces Freya and the concept of seiðr. This section provides the full treatment: the völva's role, the specific ceremony, and the complete account from the Saga of Erik the Red.

The völva (plural: vödur — "staff-carrier" or "wand-bearer," referring to the symbolic rod she always carried as a badge of office) was one of the most powerful and most specifically gendered figures in the Norse/Germanic sacred world: a female seeress and magical practitioner whose gifts gave her unique access to the future, to the spirit world, and to the threads of fate. She appears in the sagas as a figure whom even kings treated with extreme deference, as a social wanderer who traveled from community to community selling her prophetic services, and as a being whose specific sacred knowledge placed her outside normal social categories while being essential to the community's wellbeing.

Seiðr — the Practice

Seiðr (pronounced roughly "sayth") is the Norse/Germanic magical practice specifically associated with the völva — a trance-based form of sacred working involving the deliberate entry into altered consciousness, spirit contact, the perception of fate's threads, and the ability to influence what has not yet occurred. The word's etymology may connect to concepts of binding or attracting. Seiðr is distinct from the runic tradition (which works through sacred symbols) and from galdr (incantation and spoken sacred sound) — it is the domain of trance, soul-journey, and direct engagement with the spirit world.

Freya was the primary teacher and practitioner of seiðr among the gods — she taught it to Odin, who learned it despite the social stigma attached to a male practitioner (the charge of ergi — unmanliness — was applied to men who practiced seiðr, reflecting the specific gendering of the tradition). That Odin learned it regardless demonstrates the tradition's understanding that power takes priority over convention — and that wisdom, wherever it lives, is worth the cost of obtaining it.

The Ceremony — From the Saga of Erik the Red

The most complete surviving account of a seiðr session is the famous description in Chapter 4 of the Saga of Erik the Red (*Eiríks saga rauða*), describing the völva Þorbjörg arriving at a Greenland farm during a period of famine and hardship. The community needs to know when conditions will improve.

Step 1 — The Arrival: The völva arrives at the farm. She is dressed in a specific costume: a blue cloak with straps hung with stones, a necklace of glass beads, a black lamb-skin hood lined with white cat fur, cat-skin gloves, calfskin shoes with long laces and tin buttons. She carries the characteristic staff with a brass-fitted knob set with stones. She is treated as an honored guest and given the high seat.

Step 2 — The Preparation: The following evening, the ceremony is prepared. The völva needs a specific platform — the seiðhjallr — a high seat or raised platform from which she will conduct the working. She needs specific food: the hearts of every kind of animal available on the farm.

Step 3 — The Varðlokur: The ceremony cannot proceed without the varðlokur — "warding songs" or "spirit-locking songs" — specific chants sung by a circle of women to attract the helping spirits and keep the seeress safe during her trance journey. The saga records that none of the women in the household knew the varðlokur until a young woman named Guðríðr comes forward — she had learned them as a child from her foster-mother. She is reluctant to sing them (she is Christian and considers the songs incompatible with her faith) but is persuaded. The songs are described as beautiful, and the völvá says the spirits have come.

Step 4 — The Trance: The völvá enters trance on the seiðhjallr. In this state she perceives what is hidden from ordinary consciousness: the threads of fate, the actions of the spirits, the shape of what is coming.

Step 5 — The Prophecy: Coming out of trance, the völvá answers the questions of the community. She tells them: the famine will end. The conditions will improve. She then makes specific prophetic statements about several individuals present, including the young woman Guðríðr, whose extraordinary future she describes in detail. The saga's subsequent events confirm the prophecy.

The Gender Question

Seiðr was primarily the domain of women. A man who practiced it was labeled argr (or the related ergi) — a complex term combining unmanliness, passivity, and specific sexual overtones that marked him as having stepped outside acceptable masculine identity. That Odin himself was labeled argr for learning seiðr, and that he did so anyway, is one of the Norse tradition's most important statements about the relationship between power and convention: the pursuit of wisdom overrides the demands of social conformity. Modern Heathen communities generally embrace seiðr as a practice open to all practitioners regardless of gender, interpreting the historical gendering as a product of its specific cultural context rather than a universal requirement.

Theology — Wyrð, Orlog, Frith, and Hamingja

The Conceptual Framework of the Germanic Sacred World

The Germanic sacred tradition is organized around a small number of interconnected cosmological concepts that together constitute its specific understanding of how the universe works, how human beings participate in it, and what a well-lived sacred life looks like. These are not abstract philosophical principles — they are practical frameworks that shaped specific decisions, specific relationships, and specific ritual acts.

Wyrð — The Web of Fate

Wyrð (Old English; cognate with Norse Urðr, one of the three Norns) is the Anglo-Saxon word for fate — but a specific, dynamic understanding of fate quite different from the Greek concept of moira or the Roman fatum. Wyrð is not a predetermined script. It is a web — the interconnected fabric of cause and effect woven by every action, every word, every choice made by every being that exists. The three Norns (Urðr, Verðandi, and Skuld — roughly: what has been, what is becoming, what should be) sit at the Well of Urðr and weave the threads of wyrð. But they weave from what has already been given to them — the actions that have already occurred. Wyrð is simultaneously fixed (the past cannot be changed) and dynamic (the present is always generating new threads).

Orlog — The Primal Layer

Orlog (Old Norse: Örlög — primal law, primal layer) is the deepest level of wyrð — the accumulated causal weight of all past actions, extending back before individual existence. Personal orlog is the specific causal inheritance a person carries: their ancestry, the actions of their predecessors, the specific circumstances of their birth. Orlog is not chosen, but it is not destiny in a determinist sense — it is the substrate from which choice emerges. The Heathen understanding is that you do not escape your orlog; you work with it, through it, and beyond it through the quality of your present choices.

Frith and Grith — Peace and Its Conditions

Frith is the Old English/Old Norse concept of peace as a positive relational state — not merely the absence of conflict but the presence of right relationship, mutual goodwill, and the active maintenance of communal harmony. Frith is what you owe to those in your inner yard — your kin, your kindred, your community. It is built through loyalty, honesty, generosity, and the ongoing practice of right relationship. To break frith with someone is to commit a serious sacred offense. Grith is a related but distinct concept: a manufactured, specific, time-limited peace — the peace declared for a sacred gathering, a þing (assembly), or a specific sacred space. Grith is formal and contractual; frith is organic and relational.

Hamingja — The Personal Sacred Force

Hamingja is one of the most distinctively Germanic sacred concepts — a personal sacred force or luck that accompanies an individual and their family across generations. It is not mere luck in the modern sense — it is a specific quantum of sacred vitality, closely associated with the ancestor relationship, that can be strengthened through right action, through the maintenance of honor, and through the ongoing cultivation of the ancestor relationship, or diminished through dishonor, through breaking oaths, and through severing the ancestor connection. Hamingja can be gifted from one person to another (typically from ancestor to descendant or from elder to younger person in a specific

ceremony) and is understood as the sacred inheritance that makes some families consistently more fortunate, more skilled, or more courageous than others.

The Gift Cycle — Gefa

The entire Germanic sacred economy operates on the principle of gefa — the gift and its obligation. A gift demands a gift. This is not transactional in the modern commercial sense — it is a sacred relational principle that structures the relationship between humans and gods, between humans and land spirits, between members of a community, and between the living and the dead. The blót's sacrifice is a gift to the deity. The deity's blessing is the counter-gift. The sumbel's hospitality is a gift to all present. The acknowledgment of that hospitality is the counter-gift. To receive a gift and not respond with a counter-gift of appropriate weight is to break the relationship. To give extravagantly is to honor the relationship and strengthen the bonds of wyrd between the parties.

Ásatrú and Modern Heathenry

The 1972 Revival and Its Worldwide Growth

The modern revival of the Germanic pre-Christian tradition — variously called Ásatrú, Heathenry, Norse Paganism, or Germanic Neopaganism — is one of the fastest-growing new religious movements in the world. It began with a deliberate act of religious founding in Iceland in 1972 and has spread to dozens of countries with a combined following estimated at 40,000–100,000 active practitioners, with millions more who identify culturally with the tradition.

The Founding — 1972, Iceland

On May 3, 1972 — the first day of summer by the traditional Icelandic calendar — twelve Icelanders met and formally founded the Ásatrúarfélagið (Ásatrú Fellowship) with the specific intention of reviving public worship of the Norse gods, goddesses, and land spirits in Iceland. The founder and first allsherjargodi (high priest) was Sveinbjörn Beinteinsson — a farmer, poet, and performer of rímur (ancient Icelandic verse), who had never stopped feeling that the pre-Christian tradition was the authentic spiritual heritage of his people. The Icelandic government recognized the Ásatrúarfélagið as an official state-supported religious organization in 1973 — within one year of its founding. By 2025 it had 6,250 members and was Iceland's largest non-Christian religion, with legal authority to perform marriages, funerals, and naming ceremonies.

In 2015 the Ásatrúarfélagið broke ground on the first purpose-built Ásatrú temple in modern Iceland — the Hof — to be used for communal blóts, sumbels, and community gatherings. Its opening represents the most significant institutional milestone in the modern Heathenry revival.

The American Department of Defense officially recognized Ásatrú and Heathenry as valid religious designations for military service members in 2017, entitling practitioners to religious accommodation and chaplaincy services.

The Kindred System

The primary organizational unit of modern Heathenry is the kindred — a local community group of practitioners who gather for shared blót, sumbel, and other sacred observances. The kindred parallels the ancient Germanic kin-group and the Norse goðorð (the religious and political unit organized around a goði). Kindreds are typically small (10–30 members), geographically based, and self-organizing. They are affiliated with — but not subordinate to — national and international Heathen organizations.

The Branches of Modern Heathenry

Ásatrú, Fyrnsidu, Irminism, and the Diversity of the Revival

Modern Heathenry is not a single unified tradition. It is a family of related but distinct practices, each emphasizing different aspects of the Germanic heritage, different source materials, and different approaches to reconstruction versus innovation.

Ásatrú (Aesir Faith) is the broadest and most widely recognized branch — focused on the Norse gods (the Aesir and Vanir), drawing primarily from the Eddas and sagas, and organized around blót and sumbel. The Icelandic Ásatrúarfélagið is the oldest formally recognized Ásatrú organization. Ásatrú is generally universalist in its membership (open to all regardless of ancestry) in its mainstream expressions.

Fyrnsidu (The Old Customs) is the reconstructionist Anglo-Saxon path — focused on the specifically Anglo-Saxon tradition: Wōden, Þunor, Tīw, Frig, Eostre, Hretha, Mōdraniht, the Anglo-Saxon calendar and its specific observances, and the specifically Old English literary and legal tradition as primary source material. Practitioners consider it importantly distinct from the Norse tradition and resist conflating the two.

Irminism is the reconstructionist continental Germanic path — focused on the pre-Christian religion of the continental Germanic tribes (Saxons, Franks, Alemanni). It draws on Tacitus, the Merseburg Charms, the sparse continental documentary record, and Germanic folklore. The Irminsul is a central symbol. Continental variants include Saxnot worship (the specifically Saxon deity Sahsnoth, cognate with Norse Tyr) and the veneration of Nerthus.

Theodism is a tribal approach to Heathenry — emphasizing the recreation of the specific social structures of the ancient Germanic world (the þeod — people or tribe) as the primary sacred context. Practitioners organize into explicitly tribal communities with structured roles (þeodanweard — king/chief, goði,thane, etc.) and maintain a specific understanding of the inner yard/outer yard distinction in ethical practice.

Vanatrú focuses on the Vanir gods (Freyr, Freya, Njord) rather than the Aesir, emphasizing the fertility, earth-based, and seiðr aspects of the tradition over the warrior and wisdom aspects.

Forn Siðr (The Old Custom) is the Scandinavian mainland revival tradition — characterized by a more traditionalist, folklore-rooted approach than the Eddas-focused Ásatrú, emphasizing the folk religion that survived in rural Scandinavian communities across the Christian period.

The Nine Noble Virtues — A Modern Creation

One of the most widely circulated ethical codes in Heathenry is the Nine Noble Virtues (courage, truth, honour, fidelity, discipline, hospitality, industriousness, self-reliance, perseverance). These were codified in 1974 by John Yeowell and John Gibbs-Bailey of the Odinic Rite — they are a modern creation, not an ancient text. Nothing like them has been discovered in any pre-Christian Germanic source. This is not a fatal objection to their use — they are a reasonable distillation of values attested across the saga literature — but practitioners should understand their modern origin rather than treating them as ancient scripture.

Legacy and Influence

The Germanic Tradition's Footprint in the Modern World

The Germanic pre-Christian tradition has shaped the modern world more thoroughly than any other pre-Christian European sacred system — not because it was historically the most important but because its specific encoding in language, custom, and folk tradition was so thoroughgoing that conversion could suppress its practice but not erase its traces.

Language: Four English weekdays carry Germanic divine names — Tuesday (Tiw), Wednesday (Woden), Thursday (Þunor/Donar), Friday (Frig/Freya). The word Easter derives from the Anglo-Saxon goddess Eostre. The word Yule (Christmas, the winter solstice) derives from Old Norse Jól and Old English Gēol — the midwinter sacred festival. The word Berserk derives from the Old Norse berserkr — the bear-warrior or wolf-warrior in ecstatic battle trance, a specifically Germanic sacred warrior tradition. The word Nightmare derives from the Old English/Norse mare — a supernatural creature that rides sleepers and causes bad dreams.

Christmas: The specific customs of the European Christmas tradition are substantially derived from the Norse and Germanic Yule. The Yule log (burned for the twelve days of the festival to welcome the returning sun), the Christmas tree (the sacred evergreen that represents life in the dark season, possibly derived from the Irminsul or the sacred grove tradition), the exchange of gifts at midwinter, the twelve days of the festival — all predate Christian adoption. Santa Claus carries the Odinic Wild Hunt tradition in its holiday form.

Literature: J.R.R. Tolkien drew extensively and explicitly from the Germanic sacred tradition in creating Middle-earth — Odin is the template for Gandalf, the Ring mythology draws from the Völsunga saga, the Ents draw from the sacred grove tradition. Tolkien was explicit about his debt to the Norse material and furious about Nazi appropriation of it: "I have in this war a burning private grudge against that ruddy little ignoramus Adolf Hitler for ruining, perverting, misapplying and making for ever accursed, that noble northern spirit, a supreme contribution to Europe, which I have ever loved, and tried to present in its true light."

Modern Ásatrú: The Icelandic revival of 1972 has spread worldwide. By 2013 there were nearly 40,000 followers of related practices in 98 countries. The tradition is growing faster than almost any other reconstructionist religious movement.

Controversies

Nazi Appropriation, the Folkish-Universalist Split, and the Ongoing Reclamation

No tradition in this library carries a more contaminated recent history than the Germanic. Beginning in the 19th century and reaching its catastrophic peak in the Nazi period (1933–1945), the imagery, symbols, and mythology of the Germanic pre-Christian tradition were systematically appropriated by racial nationalist movements to construct a false mythology of Germanic racial superiority. The consequences are still felt in every Heathen community today.

The Nazi Appropriation

The Nazis appropriated runic symbols (particularly the Sowilō/SS rune, the Odal/Othala rune, and the various solar wheel variants), the swastika (a symbol with much broader Indo-European history that the Nazis specifically Germanicized), the concept of the Aryan race (a philological category concerning language families, twisted into a racial category without scholarly basis), and the Norse mythological framework (particularly the Ragnarök narrative of doom and heroic last stand, which provided convenient apocalyptic framing for their project). J.R.R. Tolkien's furious response — cited above — captures what serious students of the tradition understood: the Nazis were thieves who stole and defaced symbols that belonged to a broader and richer tradition than their ideology could accommodate.

The Folkish-Universalist Split

The modern Heathenry revival has been marked by an ongoing internal conflict between two incompatible positions. Folkish Heathenry holds that the Germanic tradition belongs specifically to people of Germanic/Scandinavian ancestry — that the religion and the ethnic heritage are inseparable. Some folkish organizations have been explicitly white nationalist; others claim ethnic specificity without explicit racism. The Ásatrú Folk Assembly (AFA), founded by Stephen McNallen, has been characterized by the Southern Poverty Law Center as a hate group for its explicitly exclusionary statements. Universalist Heathenry holds that the tradition is open to all who feel called to it regardless of ancestry, that the gods themselves make no racial distinctions, and that the folkish position is both historically inaccurate (the Viking Age was characterized by extensive trade, intermarriage, and cultural exchange across ethnic lines) and morally untenable.

Declaration 127 (2016) was a statement signed by hundreds of Heathen organizations worldwide explicitly rejecting the folkish position and declaring that the AFA's statements do not represent the Heathen community. It marked the most organized response to folkish ideology within the revival.

The Symbol Reclamation Effort

Individual Heathen communities and scholars continue the active work of reclaiming sacred symbols that have been appropriated by hate groups. The valknut, the Helm of Awe (Ægishjálmr), the Othala rune, and Thor's hammer (Mjölhnir) have all appeared in white supremacist contexts — creating situations where Heathens wearing their own sacred symbols may be misidentified as racists. Organizations like Heathens United Against Racism and the Alliance for Inclusive Heathenry have made reclamation and education their explicit mission. The historical and scholarly consensus is clear: the Viking Age was not a period of racial purity or ethnic isolation. The DNA evidence of Viking-Age populations

shows significant genetic diversity. The tradition is not — and never was — the exclusive property of any racial group.

The Haligric Lens

What the Germanic Pre-Christian Tradition Offers the Haligric Practitioner

The Germanic sacred tradition offers Haligricity three specific gifts of irreplaceable practical value: the most complete European model of reciprocal sacred relationship through gift-giving; the most fully articulated European framework for understanding fate as dynamic and co-created rather than fixed and predetermined; and the specific ceremonial technology of blót and sumbel as tools for community building, ancestor honoring, and sacred commitment.

The Gift Cycle and the Sacred Economy

The Germanic understanding that the sacred relationship between humans and the divine operates through a specific economy of gift and counter-gift — gefa — maps directly onto the Haligric understanding of sacred practice as active engagement rather than passive reception. The practitioner who gives — in offering, in service, in hospitality, in generosity — is not merely demonstrating virtue. They are participating in the fundamental mechanism through which the sacred world maintains its relationship with the human world. Sacred practice, in the Germanic understanding, is not something done to the practitioner by external grace. It is something the practitioner does, in relationship, in reciprocity.

Wyrd as Co-Creative Fate

The Germanic understanding of wyrd — fate as a web woven from all past actions, dynamic rather than predetermined, shaped by every choice in the present moment — is one of the most sophisticated pre-modern accounts of the relationship between causation and freedom. It refuses both determinism (the past does not constrain you absolutely) and naive free will (you cannot simply choose whatever you wish — the weight of orlog is real). The practitioner acts within a web of consequences they did not choose while weaving new threads that will shape the web for those who come after. This is the Haligric understanding of sacred responsibility: not the freedom to be anything, but the freedom to act with wisdom within what is.

Sumbel as Sacred Speech Technology

The sumbel's specific understanding — that words spoken in sacred context carry unusual weight, that oaths are binding in a cosmological sense, that the act of making a commitment before the divine and the community weaves that commitment into the fabric of wyrd — is the Germanic expression of the Haligric recognition that speaking is a dimension of sacred action, not merely its communication. What is spoken truly, in the right context, with the right witnesses, takes on a form in the sacred world that outlasts the moment of speaking. The Haligric practitioner who approaches the spoken commitment with this understanding approaches it with the gravity the tradition has always understood it to deserve.

Grand Rising. Woden hung on the tree for nine nights and received the runes screaming. The völva sat on her high platform while the women sang and the spirits came. The community sprinkled the blood on the altar and on themselves and sat down to feast with their gods. The tradition was driven underground by military conquest and forced baptism, preserved in fairy tales and the names of the days of the week, and revived by twelve people in Iceland who understood that the old gods were not dead — only waiting. It grows today in

kindreds on six continents. Wednesday still belongs to Woden. The gift demands a gift. The web is still being woven.